



SPLASHDOWN

As glaciers wind their way to the coast, they develop deep cracks called crevasses. When this fractured ice reaches the sea and starts floating, it becomes unstable, so it doesn't take much movement to make big chunks of ice fall away from the end of the glacier and crash into the water.

Icebergs

Ice shelves and the snouts of tidewater glaciers float on the sea, so they move up and down with rising and falling tides. Combined with the effects of melting, this movement makes them crack up, break into pieces, and drift away as icebergs. Many of these are small, but some icebergs are vast floating islands that can drift for huge distances in the ocean currents before melting away.

WOW!

Each year, up to 50,000 big icebergs are calved from the glaciers flowing off Greenland, and drift away across the ocean.

BREAK-UP

A tidewater glacier or an ice shelf is attached to the rock near the shore, but floats at the end nearest the ocean. The floating section of ice beyond the grounding line is thinner and, as the tide rises and falls, this flexes the floating ice until it cracks. As a result, parts of floating ice break away as icebergs—a process called calving. Since they are broken glacier ice, icebergs are made of frozen fresh water.

